

Dear Cecile

When I think of you, I see you laughing- I see your beautiful, naughty, contagious laughter, and your twinkling eyes.

And I smile. Oh Cecile, I miss you sweetheart. You have left us too early. There was still so much to do, so many more happy gatherings to have, memories to share, new memories to make.

And cakes to eat - how much you loved my custard cake! (the Croatian recipe from my mum). First time I made it, it was a long time ago - for one of our Russian Christmas parties in London, organised by you, Kathy and Fenella.

Those Christmas parties were lovely Cecile - we were so grateful - for what you did at the time for our Russian children's community was incredible. I think as much as it was important for the children, it was invaluable to us, the parents. Thank you darling Cecile.

And the children - they were toddlers then - all adorable, rosy-cheeked and happy. So much joy in that one room.

And the story continued...

Then, about 15 years later, the last time we shared a cake was when you came to see me, a couple of summers ago. We laughed - you still talked about 'the yellow cake'. On this occasion, I think I made brownies - it was too hot a day to be faffing about baking the more elaborate cake. But I promised to make it for you, the next time...

As our children were becoming a bit older, and nearly living independently, I was hoping to be seeing more of you, was hoping to have a bit more time for reminiscing/knitting, time for summer lunches and beach walks - like old ladies do.

I was hoping to be getting old and growing old alongside friends like you.. we have our own very special bond, our stories, the understanding, the shared history.

I miss you Cecile, and will carry you forever in my heart - you brave, beautiful, untamed soul.

May you rest in peace dear friend, you deserve it.

Nina Bjelica